

In the last piece, I talked about the quiet shift from asking for permission to simply informing. How your sentences change from “Can I” to “I’m doing this,” and how that small change rearranges the entire relationship. Before that, I wrote about how independence can start looking like disrespect, especially when the person watching you is still holding onto the version of you that asked before deciding.

This is the next shift. The quieter one. The heavier one.

The moment you realize your parents know you, but not really you. And the even quieter realization that you are now responsible for the parts of yourself they no longer guide. It is the realization that while you were out here becoming a whole new person, they were still holding onto the "legacy version" of your identity. It is like they are trying to navigate a new city with an old, dusty map from twenty years ago. The landmarks have shifted, the roads have been renamed, and the person living there is someone they haven't been properly introduced to yet.

They know your childhood version. The one that liked certain foods, feared the dark, needed help choosing clothes, and shared every thought without filtering. They know the child they raised, not always the adult you became. And the gap is not loud. It is subtle. It shows up in small misunderstandings that feel too minor to correct but too frequent to ignore.

It is your mother recommending a "stable" path when you have already committed to the chaos of creation. It is your father offering advice for a version of you that was afraid of the world, not realizing you have already survived things that would have terrified that younger version. It is the disconnect between the "you" that exists in their nostalgia and the "you" that is currently navigating the streets of Nairobi.

They recommend things you would never choose. They describe you using traits that no longer fit. They assume you like what you liked years ago. They give advice based on a personality you have quietly outgrown. You sit there listening and realize something uncomfortable. The person they are talking about still exists in their mind, but you have moved on. They are praising a ghost, and you are the one left trying to fill the shoes of a version of yourself you don't even remember being.

They remember the shy version of you. You have learned to speak up.

They remember the obedient version of you. You have learned to question.

They remember the predictable version of you. You have learned to change.

And none of this happened suddenly. It unfolded gradually, while you were living your life outside their daily view. While you were handling crises they never heard about, navigating professional mazes, and deciding which parts of your history you wanted to keep and which you

wanted to shed. You were evolving in the dark, and now that you are standing in the light, they are still squinting to see the child they remember.

You developed new fears they never saw forming. You built boundaries they never watched you draw. You changed your mind about things they still think you believe. You became more private, more layered, more independent. You started realizing that privacy isn't secrecy. It is just the space where your adult self lives, away from the expectations of the people who knew you when you were small.

And independence does something unexpected. It makes you lonelier in certain ways.

Not dramatically. Not in a tragic sense. Just in the quiet reality that you are now making decisions without the automatic emotional cushioning you used to have. You no longer run every choice through someone who feels responsible for you. You decide. Then you carry the weight of that decision alone. You realize that "having it all figured out" is a performance we all do, and you are the lead actor, director, and stage manager of your own show.

You choose a path they don't fully understand. You cannot lean on their certainty. You try something new. You cannot borrow their confidence. You make a mistake. You cannot soften it by saying, we decided. It is only you. It is you sitting in your room at 10 PM, looking at a problem, and realizing that the "adult" in the room is actually just you in a different outfit. There is no one to call for a "second opinion" that carries more weight than your own internal compass.

This is where self parenting begins.

You start comforting yourself the way a parent would. You calm your own anxiety. You talk yourself through fear. You set your own boundaries. You remind yourself to rest. You tell yourself it will be okay, even when you are not entirely sure. You become the one who tells yourself to drink water, to breathe, and to stop overthinking the email you sent at 4:59 PM. You learn to be the voice that says, *"You did well today, even if it didn't feel like it."*

You become the voice that used to guide you. And that shift is both empowering and exhausting. Because independence is not only freedom. It is responsibility without delegation. You do not only choose your direction. You also carry the emotional consequences of choosing wrong, choosing late, choosing differently. You are the only person who can truly forgive yourself for your own mistakes. You are the one who has to pick yourself up when the "independence" feels a bit too cold.

Your friendships shift too.

You start gravitating toward people who understand this version of you. People who know your current thoughts, not your childhood identity. Friends become witnesses to your adulthood in a

way your parents no longer are. They see your confusion in real time. Your growth in progress. Your contradictions as they form. They are the ones who see the work you are actually doing, the way you are coding your future, and the way you are navigating the hustle of 2026.

And slowly, you realize something bittersweet. Some of your friends now know you more closely than your parents do.

They know your current fears. Your relationship patterns. Your work stress. Your evolving beliefs. Not because they love you more, but because they are present in this phase of your life. Your parents love you deeply. But they are loving from memory and instinct. Your friends are loving from observation. One is an archive; the other is a live stream. Your parents love the version of you that stayed safe; your friends love the version of you that is currently taking risks.

That gap is not anyone's fault. It is simply what growing up does. You stop being fully known by the people who raised you. And you start being known by people who met you later. That transition is quiet, but emotional. Because you still want your parents to understand you. You still want them to see the full picture. But you also realize that some parts of you were built outside their view. And explaining them feels complicated. It is like trying to explain a complex software update to someone who was perfectly happy with the original version and doesn't see why you needed to "fix" what wasn't broken.

So you start reintroducing yourself slowly. Not dramatically. Not defensively. Just honestly. You share new opinions. You reveal new priorities. You disagree gently. You show them the adult version in small pieces. You let them see that you can handle the path you've chosen, even if it's not the one they would have paved for you. You show them that the "you" they raised was strong enough to become the "you" they are now meeting.

And at the same time, you learn to parent yourself through the space between who they think you are and who you've become. You learn to bridge the gap with kindness—both for them, and for the version of you that is still learning how to be "grown." You learn that their lack of understanding isn't a lack of love. It is just a lack of context.

Growing up is not only becoming independent. It is becoming responsible for your own emotional safety. Your own decisions. Your own reassurance. Your own direction. It is realizing that the voice guiding you now sounds a lot like your parents, but it is coming from inside you. It is their strength, repurposed for your own journey. It is the realization that you have become the person you used to look for when things got hard.

And that is both lonely and beautiful. It is the moment you realize you aren't actually alone in this—you are just the one in charge. And as you look at your peers, you see them doing the same: quietly parenting themselves, making it up as they go, and realizing that the tea is just as good even without the extra sugar of someone else's approval. You realize that everyone else is

also just a "kid" in an adult suit, trying to figure out which voice to listen to. And in that shared, silent understanding, you finally feel like you have come home. Not to the house you grew up in, but to the person you have finally become.